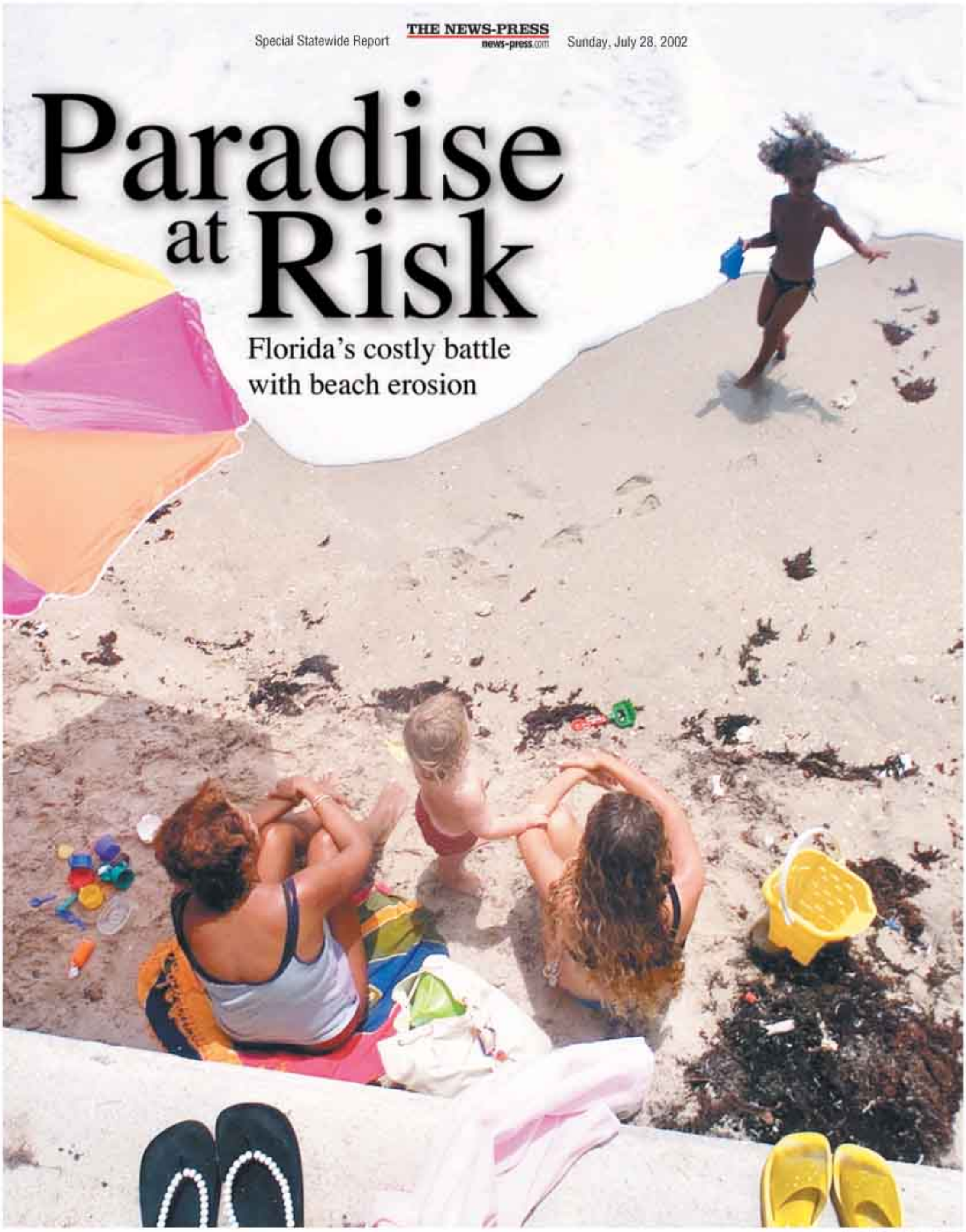
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Paradise at Risk

Florida's costly battle with beach erosion



Andrew West, The News-Press

Barely a beach: Korinna Castro, 3, top, stays ahead of the surf while playing on a south Broward County beach in Hallandale with her mother, Cristina Castro, and friends Marisol De Pascal and her 5-month-old, Gianluca. On some waves, the surf would reach the seawall, sweeping toys and beach supplies into the Atlantic Ocean. A $45 million project to widen the beach is expected to start this fall.

State defends shrinking shoreline

As tides continue to devour the coast, a building boom fuels renourishment projects



Michael R. Brown, FLORIDA TODAY

Turtle trouble: Alex Von Edwins, 14, of Palm Bay stands on the beach in Indialantic near an erosion cliff that hampers sea turtles from getting to the sand dune area so they can lay their eggs during nesting season.

By Anton Caputo

As the Atlantic Ocean and Gulf of Mexico grind away at Florida's beaches, they threaten the state's most valuable — and most vulnerable — real estate. Some fear that as Florida beaches erode, so does its livelihood: tourism and development.

No beaches. No tourists.

No beaches. No growth.

And the beaches are at risk.

Of 825 miles of sandy beach, roughly half are eroding; 328 miles — the distance from Jacksonville to Fort Lauderdale — are being eaten away to the point buildings and recreation are threatened. So valuable are the beaches that taxpayers fight back, pumping sand and money — at least $886 million since 1923 — onto the shores.

Pumping and trucking sand to rebuild eroding beaches will continue at even higher prices as near-shore supplies of sand dwindle.

Florida is trapped in a risky cycle of erosion, building up beaches and building on beaches. From April 2001 through April 2002, the state Department of Environmental Protection has issued 266 permits for homes and hotels on the state's sandy shores. More than half are along critically eroded beaches that qualify for taxpayer money to pay for new sand.

SHORE: Continued on Page 3

Inside this section you'll find:



Michael Spooneybarger, Pensacola News Journal

High and dry: A canoe rests on the shore of Eagle Harbor, near St. Joseph's Bay in Gulf County. St. Joseph's Beach was named the best beach in the nation.

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Risky building
Like rolling the dice, when Floridians take a chance building on sand, they risk losing everything. The state has endorsed building thousands of homes that could be devoured by the tide before their mortgages are cleared.

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The beach economy
Without healthy beaches to fuel tourism and development, Florida's economy could founder.

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Policy and politics
■ A small group of coastal engineers continues to land contracts for beach projects and also sets state renourishment policies.
■ While more than $800 million has been spent on Florida beaches, we haven't spent the most. Find out which state has.

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Erosion causes
Mother Nature doesn't deserve all the blame. Humans are main source of Florida's erosion.

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Impact on wildlife
Despite the mess made fixing a beach, most wildlife flourish on rebuilt shores.

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Science of sand
Panelists dig into sand samples from around the state. Find out which were their favorites.

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Two views, one goal
Two longtime newsmen from Florida share different views on the erosion problem and the future of the state's beaches.